MIRZA AZIZ KOKA IN MECCA

When Akbar reached Kashmir in 1592, he was once again delighted with the country. ‘On my first visit, I saw the bridal chamber of spring,’ he said, ‘now I behold the coquetry of autumn.’ The harem and the imperial camp had been left behind at Rohtas Fort because of inclement weather, in the charge of Mirza Daniyal. En route, Salim’s son Khusrau was suddenly taken so ill that ‘he was committed to the care of God and [Akbar] made up his mind to part from him’. Though Khusrau would soon recover, Akbar rushed away from his beloved grandson, seemingly unable to stand helplessly by while the child languished. Instead, Akbar and a small group of men, including Salim, made their way through snow, rain, and wind to reach Srinagar. There they discovered an enormous chinar tree with a hollow trunk, into which thirty-four persons were easily made to sit. ‘If they had sat closer,’ grumbled Abu’l Fazl, ‘more might have been accommodated.’

These bucolic pastimes notwithstanding, the situation in Kashmir was uncertain. Srinagar was found to be ominously deserted and the villages similarly abandoned. Enquiries had been made after the conquest of Kashmir into the amount of revenue collected from the region, which was meant to be one-third of the produce. However, a number of irregularities had crept in with jagirdars in the past using coercive methods and appropriating a great deal more than they were entitled to. So Akbar had sent officials to assess the situation and implement the correct revenue. Yadgar, the governor’s cousin, had been executed on charges of embezzlement and his head was presented to the Padshah. Expecting further troubles and punishments, the locals had all melted away into the countryside. ‘Although the root of the rebellion had been dug up,’ wrote Abu’l Fazl, ‘yet, owing to a report that His Majesty had ordered the punishment of high and low, people had scattered, and there was no population in any of the villages.’ Now efforts were made to placate the terrified population and those who had not participated in the rebellions were richly rewarded.